

LN905 Advanced English: Informal Travel Vocabulary Exercises

Contextual Usage Paragraphs – Read the following paragraphs and underline any words or phrases whose meaning you are uncertain about. Then compare with a partner and discuss, from the context, what you think the words or phrases might mean.

Paragraph 1: The Budget Traveler

After catching the travel bug during a college semester abroad, Marcus knew he wanted to see the world despite his limited finances. Fresh out of university, he decided to take a gap year and go backpacking through Southeast Asia on a complete shoestring budget. His wanderlust was so strong that he didn't mind sleeping in hostels, eating street food, and taking twelve-hour bus rides to save money. He deliberately sought out destinations off the beaten path, avoiding tourist traps and instead discovering local hangouts where he could practice his language skills with friendly locals. The culture shock was intense at first - everything from eating habits to social customs seemed completely foreign - but Marcus found that embracing these differences made his journey far more rewarding than any luxury vacation could have been.

Paragraph 2: The Seasoned Explorer

Catherine had always been a natural jet-setter, but her globe-trotting adventures reached new heights after she sold her successful tech company. With wanderlust that had been suppressed by years of corporate life, she began checking items off her bucket list at an incredible pace. Last month's road trip through Patagonia was followed by a cultural immersion program in rural Japan, where the initial culture shock of traditional village life gradually gave way to deep appreciation. Unlike her younger backpacking days when she travelled on a shoestring budget, Catherine now preferred seeking out authentic local hangouts and supporting small businesses rather than falling into obvious tourist traps. Her travel bug had evolved from simple adventure-seeking into a genuine desire to understand different ways of life around the globe.

Paragraph 3: The Reluctant Homebody

Despite his friends' constant globe-trotting adventures and their attempts to give him the travel bug, David had never experienced true wanderlust. The thought of jet lag, culture shock, and navigating unfamiliar places filled him with anxiety rather than excitement. While his colleagues planned gap years and elaborate backpacking expeditions, David discovered the joy of the staycation - exploring hiking trails, museums, and local hangouts within a few hours' drive of his home. His shoestring budget actually worked in his favour, as he found incredible off the beaten path locations right in his own region. When friends returned from their road trips with stories of overpriced tourist traps and cultural misunderstandings, David felt validated in his choice to be a jet-setter of local adventures, proving that you don't need a passport to add meaningful experiences to your bucket list.

Target Vocabulary

Backpacking - traveling with minimal luggage, often on a budget

Globe-trotting - traveling frequently to many different countries

Jet lag - fatigue from traveling across time zones

Wanderlust - strong desire to travel

Road trip - long journey by car

Staycation - vacation spent at home or nearby

Shoestring budget - very limited amount of money

Off the beaten path - away from popular tourist areas

Culture shock - disorientation in unfamiliar cultural environment

Travel bug - enthusiasm for traveling

Local hangouts - places where locals spend time

Tourist trap - overpriced place targeting tourists

Gap year - year off for travel/experience

Bucket list - list of things to do before you die

Jet-setter - person who travels frequently by plane

Exercise 1: Gap Fill

Complete the sentences with the appropriate informal travel vocabulary.

1. After graduating from university, Sarah decided to take a _____ and spend twelve months backpacking through Southeast Asia.
2. The restaurant near the cathedral was clearly a _____ - they charged €25 for a simple pasta dish that would cost €8 anywhere else.
3. Mike's been suffering from terrible _____ ever since he flew back from Tokyo yesterday; he keeps falling asleep during meetings.
4. Instead of booking an expensive resort, we're planning a _____ this summer and exploring the hiking trails within driving distance of our city.
5. Lisa's got the _____ again - she's already booked flights to three different countries for this year and it's only March.
6. The guidebook recommended avoiding the main square and seeking out _____ where you can experience authentic local cuisine.
7. Traveling across Europe on a _____ means staying in hostels, cooking your own meals, and taking overnight buses instead of flights.
8. Emma's always had terrible _____, so she knew that one day she'd quit her corporate job and become a travel blogger.
9. My parents have become real _____ since they retired - last month they were in Morocco, and next week they're flying to Vietnam.
10. Visiting that remote village in the mountains was definitely worth getting _____ - we didn't see another tourist for three days.

Exercise 2: Matching Definitions

Match each informal travel term with its correct definition.

1. Jet-setter
2. Culture shock
3. Road trip
4. Globe-trotting
5. Bucket list
6. Tourist trap
7. Backpacking
8. Staycation
9. Shoestring budget
10. Local hangouts

a) A list of experiences or destinations you want to achieve before you die b) Places where residents of an area typically spend their leisure time c) Traveling with minimal possessions, usually staying in budget accommodations d) A vacation spent at home or in nearby familiar places e) The feeling of disorientation when encountering an unfamiliar culture f) A person who travels frequently and luxuriously, especially by private jet g) Traveling extensively to many different countries around the world h) A long journey taken by car, often with multiple stops i) Having very little money available for expenses j) A business or attraction that charges excessive prices to tourists

Exercise 3: Sentence Transformation

Rewrite each sentence using the informal travel vocabulary provided in brackets. Make any necessary grammatical changes.

1. John has an intense desire to explore new places and cultures. (wanderlust)
2. The couple decided to take a vacation without leaving their hometown. (staycation)
3. After her flight from Australia, Maria felt extremely tired due to the time difference. (jet lag)
4. The family planned to drive across the country, stopping at various national parks. (road trip)
5. That expensive restaurant near the tourist area clearly overcharges visitors. (tourist trap)
6. Despite having very little money, they managed to travel through South America for six months. (shoestring budget)
7. The remote mountain village was far from the usual tourist destinations. (off the beaten path)

8. Since retiring, Patricia has been traveling constantly to different countries around the world.
(globe-trotting)
 9. The shock of experiencing such a different culture was overwhelming at first. (culture shock)
 10. Carrying everything in a backpack, they traveled cheaply through Europe for three months.
(backpacking)
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